finish ninth in the batch of 25 examined to select eight officers for commissioning in the Air Force. I was deeply disappointed. It took me some time to comprehend that the opportunity to join the Air Force had just slipped through my fingers. I dragged myself out of the Selection Board and stood at the edge of a cliff. There was a lake far below. I knew that the days ahead would be difficult. There were questions to be answered and a plan of action to be prepared. I trekked down to Rishikesh.

I bathed in the Ganga and revel ed in the purity of its water. Then, I walked to the Sivananda Ashram situated a little way up the hil . I could feel intense vibrations when I entered. I saw a large number of sadhus seated al around in a state of trance. I had read that sadhus were psychic people—people who know things intuitively and, in my dejected mood, I sought answers to the doubts that troubled me.

I met Swami Sivananda—a man who looked like a Buddha, wearing a snow-white dhoti and wooden slippers. He had an olive complexion and black, piercing eyes. I was struck by his irresistible, almost childlike smile and gracious manner. I introduced myself to the Swamiji. My